preparation of the Report on Indian Constitutional Reforms by Montagu along with the Viceroy Lord Chelmsford, which was completed in Simla on 22 April 1918 and published on 8 July 1918.[3] The importance of these Reforms, which were popularly known as the Montagu–Chelmsford Reforms or the Montford Reforms for short, in Bharat's constitutional journey is evident from the fact that they formed the direct basis of the Government of India Act of 1919.[4]

For all practical purposes, it could be said that the Government of India Act of 1919 was the first British-made Constitution for India, which provided the foundation for the Government of India Act of 1935. The 1935 Act, in turn, provided the broader framework for the Constitution of independent India, as admitted by the Chairman of the Drafting Committee of the Constitution, Dr. Ambedkar, in the Constituent Assembly Debates.[5] Since the foundational document is the Montford Report, those who wish to understand the origins of independent Bharat's constitutional framework must read the 256-page Report which, among other things, is a one-stop shop of sorts to understand the evolution of the British politico-legal and administrative infrastructure in Bharat. The Report consists of 11 chapters and a conclusion, but I will discuss only those portions that are relevant to the theme of the discussion at hand, namely colonial consciousness and its influence on contemporary constitutionalism.

In Chapter VII of Part I of the Report, the authors rejected the Congress–League scheme for self-government citing its 'unworkability in practice' and its 'negation of responsible government'. In short, according to Montagu and Chelmsford, Bharat was not ready for self-government even within the British Empire. In Part II of the Report, the proposals of the authors are set out along with the reasons in Paragraphs 178–199. These portions of the Report, according to me, are mandatory reading to understand the continuing colonial consciousness and civilising tendencies of the Christian coloniser. Here are a few extracts which speak for themselves, lest it is assumed that I am reading the document with a confirmation bias:

> Reasons for a new policy
>
> 178. … It is evident that the present machinery of government no longer meets the needs of the time; it works slowly, and it produces